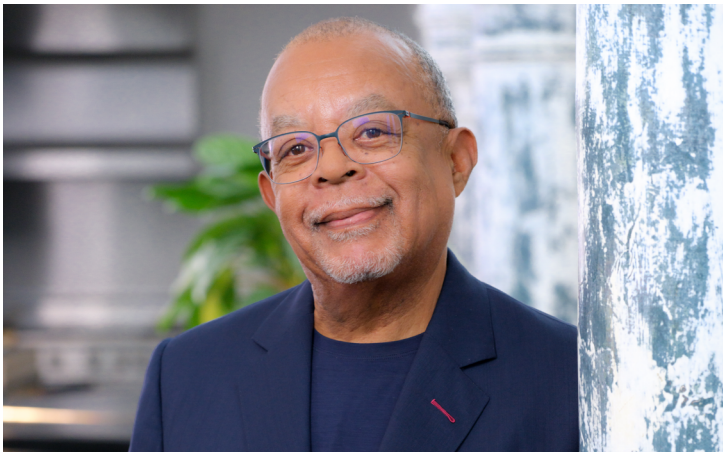
How to Bring the Real You to Work: Authenticity, Connection, and Identity

The Many Components of Identity

- Identity is composed of both social labels (e.g., race, gender, class) and personal identifiers (e.g., passions, values, personality traits).
- Social identities are externally assigned and can be linked to stereotypes that may distort how others perceive us.
- Personal identities are self-defined and reflect the deeper, individual truths we hold about ourselves.
- Being aware of both social and personal identities helps us resist imposed limitations and express our full selves.

Imposed Identities in the Workplace

- Imposed identities can lead to stereotype threat, reducing one's confidence and performance. Microaggressions, often subtle and unintentional, can also compound feelings of exclusion and othering.
- Strategies such as self-affirmation, growth mindset, and microinterventions offer ways to reclaim agency in biased environments.



- Maintaining authenticity requires discernment between strategic adaptation and practices that can erase one's core identity, such as code-switching.
- Reframing internal narratives and affirming your earned place in professional spaces are critical tools for combating self-doubt, including imposter syndrome.

Achieving Authenticity at Work

- Authenticity involves consciously choosing which parts of yourself to bring forward in professional spaces, and why. It is not about sharing everything—it's about making intentional, aligned choices that reflect your core self.
- Setting boundaries informed by workplace norms and personal comfort enables individuals to express themselves while respecting the environment.
- Honest communication, deep listening, and vulnerability support stronger, more authentic professional relationships.
- Staying aligned with personal values helps sustain a sense of purpose and confidence, even when challenged.
- Encouraging authenticity in others—by fostering inclusive environments and showing openness—creates space for everyone to express themselves genuinely.

"We're all kaleidoscopes of inner and outer identities, influences, histories, and passions."

—Professor Henry Louis Gates Jr.

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"I know we hear the phrase 'You are enough' [...], but you are. There is something about each individual that is different from the next, which makes you special. And so, be comforted in that individual speciality that you are."

—Cynthia Erivo

Keep in Mind

- **Your identity is unique and ever-changing.** You are made up of both your personal and your social identities. Who you are changes as you learn and grow.
- **How others see you can affect your work experience.** Stereotypes and social labels can shape how you're seen and treated at work. Recognizing these influences is the first step to challenging them.
- **Being yourself at work is powerful—when done thoughtfully.** Being authentic means balancing your self-expression with your understanding of norms and expectations at your workplace.
- **Inclusion helps you, your colleagues, and your workplace.** Diversity is about having different people in the room; inclusion is about making sure everyone feels valued and able to contribute. When you help others feel included, everyone benefits.
- **You can develop skills that help you thrive at work.** From setting boundaries to finding mentors and learning to handle conflict, there are techniques you can follow to overcome challenges, stay true to yourself, and help others do the same.

Strategies

- **Reflect on your identity**: Regularly check in with yourself about who you are and what matters to you. Notice which parts of your identity you bring to work and which parts you might be hiding—and ask yourself why.
- **Recognize and challenge stereotypes and bias:** Be aware of stereotypes and social labels. If you notice bias or microaggressions, pause to reflect and, when appropriate, respectfully address them.
- **Stay true to core values while adapting thoughtfully:** Code-switching and adjusting your behavior depending on the context is natural, but don't lose sight of what really matters to you. Consider which values or aspects of your identity you are unwilling to hide, and express them in ways that align with your workplace.
- **Reframe self-doubt and practice self-affirmation:** Replace negative self-talk with positive, affirming thoughts. Celebrate your successes and remind yourself that you deserve to be where you are.
- **Foster inclusion for others:** Inclusive workplaces start with small, everyday actions that make everyone feel welcome and valued.

The Bottom Line

Identity is multifaceted, shaped by both internal self-perceptions and external social labels. Authenticity in the workplace requires recognizing these layers and resisting pressures that force conformity or self-erasure. While professional norms may demand adaptation, long-term success and well-being come from aligning one's actions with core values and self-knowledge.

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